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PODCAST

« I don't do politics, I do sports »

SHARATH KAMAL

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In August 2023, Achanta Sharath Kamal, the 10-time national table tennis champion, slipped out of the Top 100 in the ITTF Rankings, which was soon followed by a disappointing campaign at the Hangzhou Asian Games.

However, less than a year after hitting that low, the 41-year-old first helped the Indian men's team reach the round-of-16 at the World Team Championships in Busan in February, which made it possible to clinch a historic Paris Olympics quota for the team event via world rankings. He then reinstated himself as the country's top-ranked player, jumping from 88 to 34 in the ITTF Rankings after a sensational run from qualifiers to the quarterfinals of the Singapore Smash event, and is now a prime contender for one of the two quotas India will get for the men's singles event.

Sharath, who has won 13 Commonwealth Games medals (including seven gold) and two Asian Games bronze medals over his two-decade-long career, has also been announced as the flagbearer of the Indian contingent for the opening ceremony of the Paris Games, which will be his fifth Olympics.

In an interview with *Sportstar*, Sharath reflects on India's qualification for both team events for Paris 2024, his amazing run in Singapore, his post-retirement plans and more.

If, at the beginning of the event in Singapore, someone had told you that you would reach the quarterfinals, what would have been your response?

When my wife and son asked me when I would return, I said I'd come back on Sunday when the main draw's first round starts. I said if I can make it, I'll make it to the main draw in the first round. Beyond that, I'm not very sure. I played until next week's Friday. In between, my son was asking, "Which Sunday did you say you would come home?"

I didn't expect it, but when I look back, there are a lot of attributes that went into the kind of mindset I was in. The first thing was the qualification for the Olympic Games after the World Team Championships.

For the last six to eight months, my primary focus after the Asian Games or even one year prior was on qualification for the team event. I knew that we had a chance at it because we were around there with the rankings, and that would make a

big difference to Indian table tennis. The whole focus was on making sure that we got into the Olympic Games in the team championships, and that's one thing that I had never done in my career. We beat Kazakhstan on a very close front. One or two teams had to lose at the same time. So, the combinations worked very well, and we made it. Once we made it, a lot of pressure was off our minds.

Also, I knew I had to go into Singapore Smash because it was so close to the World Championships. So, the match practice and the whole mental frame that I would be in for the World Championships would carry forward into the Singapore smash. I had the confidence to qualify for the Olympic Games. I went into that tournament physically and mentally fit, with no pressure at all.

I had lost to a player from Japan (Yuta Tanaka) six months ago at the Asian Championships, and he had beaten me 4-1. I didn't have a challenge there. When I beat him 3-0



With my administrative roles with Indian Olympic Association (IOA) and International Table Tennis Federation (ITTF), I want to build a good ecosystem for table tennis.